

THE GOLDFISH

Dorado



SIZE RANKING 72

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.3

GENITIVE Doradus

ABBREVIATION Dor

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
December–JanuaryFULLY VISIBLE
20°N–90°S

Dorado is one of the southern constellations introduced in the late 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (p.416). Although known as the goldfish, Dorado in fact represents the dolphinfish found in tropical waters, not common aquarium and pond fish. The constellation has also been depicted as a swordfish.

Most of the Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) is contained within Dorado, although this mini-galaxy also extends into Mensa. The first recorded mention of the Large Magellanic Cloud is credited to al-Sufi (see panel, below).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The Large Magellanic Cloud is a satellite galaxy of the Milky Way. It is situated some 179,000 light-years away from the Earth and, at first sight, looks like a detached part of the Milky Way. Its numerous star clusters and

SUPERNOVA 1987A

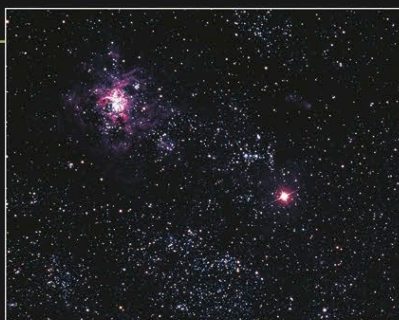
This supernova has faded since its dramatic flare-up in 1987. To its upper left in this image is the spider-like Tarantula Nebula.

nebulous patches are brought into view through binoculars or a small telescope.

A remarkable object in the Large Magellanic Cloud is the Tarantula Nebula, or NGC 2070. It is bright enough to be visible with the naked eye and can be seen well through binoculars. A cluster of newborn stars at the heart of the Tarantula Nebula can be detected through binoculars or a small telescope, while photographs show its looping extremities, like a spider's legs, from which this large nebula of glowing gas gets its popular name.

In February 1987, a supernova flared up in the Large Magellanic Cloud. Supernova 1987A, as it was called, reached 3rd magnitude in May of that year, and this made it the brightest supernova visible from Earth since 1604. It remained visible to the naked eye for 10 months.

Beta (β) Doradus is one of the brightest Cepheid variables, ranging between magnitudes 3.5 and 4.1 every 9.8 days, while R Doradus is an erratic red giant that varies from 5th to 6th magnitude every 11 months or so.

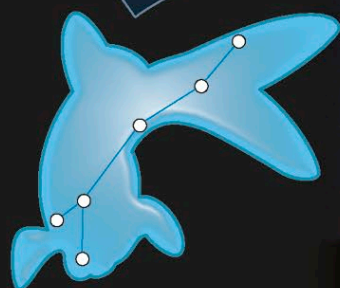
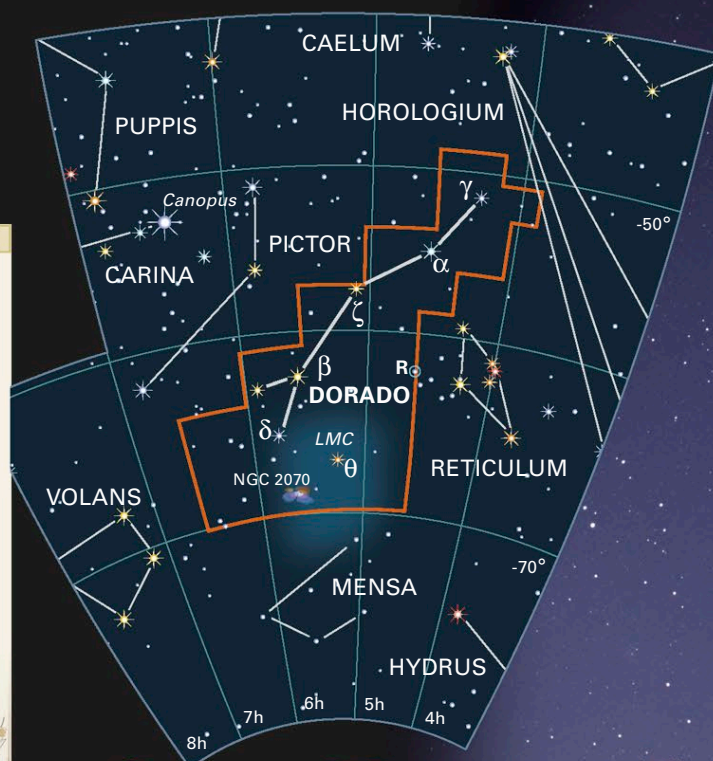


THE LMC

The brighter of the two mini-galaxies that accompany our own, the Large Magellanic Cloud appears elongated in shape. It includes the Tarantula Nebula (here on its upper-left edge).

HEADING SOUTH

Dorado, the Goldfish, swims through the southern skies, apparently on its way to the south celestial pole.



THE GOLDFISH

AL-SUFI

Abd al-Rahman al-Sufi (903–986 CE), known also by his Latinized name, Azophi, was an Arabic astronomer. Around 964 CE, he produced the *Book of the Fixed Stars*—an updated version of Ptolemy's *Almagest*—which introduced many star names still in use today. Later editions of the book contained Arabic illustrations of the constellations (like the one below).

CONSTELLATION PORTRAIT

A version of al-Sufi's *Book of the Fixed Stars* was produced in the 16th century by a Persian artist. It included this image of Boötes.

